



less gifted athletes succeed.

- They use imagery and similes in coaching, painting pictures in athletes' minds. "Jump as high as you can" becomes "Push the floor away like a rocket blasting into space."

- Separate learning from practice. They understand that practice begins only after athletes have properly learned a skill, avoiding the reinforcement of bad habits. Learning happens through close observation and direct coaching.

- Help the athlete focus on what to do, not what to avoid. They say "Shoulders squared and core tight" instead of "Don't fall over."

- Use multiple methods of teaching. They incorporate auditory, visual, and kinesthetic approaches, acknowledging that people learn differently.

- They understand child development, with a working knowledge of developmental milestones, and adapt their approach to meet athletes where they are.

- They wind up practice before players are exhausted, as fatigue often leads to poor habits and shortcuts.

- They give sufficient time for new skills to develop and be incorporated. Coaches typically need at least eight weeks for a player to learn a new skill. As the athlete progresses, that time frame tends to get longer, not shorter, as skills become more complex.

- Use positive coaching techniques. Brilliant coaches do not yell, belittle, threaten, or intimidate. They do not rely on bullying to get results. While short-term success may occur under such pressure-filled environments, a brilliant coach understands that, in the long run, these methods backfire and harm development.

- Have a growth mindset. They believe skills can be developed through dedication and hard work. They emphasise this consistently, so their athletes remain motivated.

- Know what they don't know. Brilliant coaches are not afraid to admit that they don't have all the answers. They do not let ego prevent them from seeking additional help, training, or even recommending that an athlete move to a more experienced coach. They keep an open mind about their own

A bond of a lifetime: Brilliant coaches understand the importance of emotional connection, making athletes feel more important as people than as athletes, which gives them deeper levels of engagement. GETTY IMAGES

knowledge.

- Educate their athletes. They go beyond instruction, helping athletes understand the purpose behind drills, skill sequences, and conditioning.

- They have clear rules and logical consequences, applied fairly and consistently to all athletes, including the most talented.

- Always end sessions on a positive note. They always find a way to seek a positive end to even the most difficult of sessions. They know that both success and failure are temporary.

- Finally, they recognise that fun is a crucial element of training, no matter how elite the level. The primary reason many players quit sport is that they stop enjoying it. Fun is not a trivial sentiment but the foundation of an athlete's healthy commitment to any sport.